

Rudra, the Howler of the Vedas

Rudra is one of the oldest and most complex figures in the Vedic pantheon. Appearing in the Rig-Veda, this god occupies a special place among the deities of that era. His name, derived from a root that evokes howling or roaring, designates him as the Howler, the Terrible, or the Ruddy One. He embodies the wild force of storms, wind, and untamed nature. As a divine archer, he travels the sky in a chariot, armed with a bow and arrows capable of bringing both disease and death as well as healing. The hymns describe him as a young and powerful being, with braided hair, a complexion shining like gold or the sun, adorned with precious ornaments. Yet behind this radiant appearance lies an ambivalent nature: fearsome and unpredictable on one side, benevolent and the physician of the gods on the other. He is prayed to spare men and cattle, while also being asked for his thousand remedies capable of relieving ailments.

In the Vedic texts, Rudra remains a relatively minor deity in terms of the number of hymns dedicated to him, but one of recognized power. He is the father of the Maruts, those storm gods who accompany him. Over time, his image evolves. In the Yajur-Veda and the Brāhmaṇas, he gains importance. The epithet “Shiva,” meaning the Auspicious or the Benevolent, first appears as a way to appease this dreaded god. Gradually, this epithet becomes a proper name and eventually designates the great figure who absorbs and surpasses Rudra. Thus, Rudra constitutes the direct precursor of Shiva. What is sometimes called Rudra-Shiva marks this historical and theological continuity: the wild and fierce god of the Vedas transforms, without denying himself, into the great god of destruction, regeneration, and asceticism of later periods.

The cult of Rudra reflects this duality. Among his most characteristic worshippers were the *Vrātyas*, those groups of itinerant warriors and non-conformists who lived on the margins of orthodox Vedic society. Organized male bands following particular rules, they frequented wild spaces and celebrated collective rituals. Rudra was a privileged deity for them, mirroring their own status as outsiders. Their leader sometimes embodied the archer god himself. Beyond these marginal circles, Rudra was also propitiated by Vedic priests and heads of families. The hymns of the Rig-Veda and especially the long litany of the Śatarudrīya in the Yajur-Veda testify to this ritual devotion. Sacrifices were offered to him, notably that of an ox, to protect herds and households. Herders and hunters particularly venerated him under his aspect as Paśupati, lord of animals. Inhabitants of forests and mountains, groups living on the fringes of sedentary society, found in him a god who resembled them. Later, emerging ascetic currents, precursors of Shaiva traditions, continued this devotion by emphasizing his wild and transformative character.

Thus, Rudra was not merely a god to be feared. He was also the one called upon for health, protection, and strength. His cult, both propitiatory and respectful, crossed different layers of Vedic society, from ritual elites to the most peripheral groups. It is this richness and ambivalence that allowed the figure of Rudra to gradually transform into that of Shiva, while preserving, in the religious memory of India, the memory of the howler of the storms and the lord of wild spaces.